

When blame inevitably arises, the most senior people in the room should repeat this mantra: if a mistake happens, shame on us for making it so easy to make that mistake. In a Five Whys analysis, we want to have a systems-level view as much as possible.

Here's a situation in which this mantra came in handy. Because of the training process we had developed at IMVU through the Five Whys, we routinely asked new engineers to make a change to the production environment on their first day. For engineers trained in traditional development methods, this was often frightening. They would ask, "What will happen to me if I accidentally disrupt or stop the production process?" In their previous jobs, that was a mistake that could get them fired. At IMVU we told new hires, "If our production process is so fragile that you can break it on your very first day of work, shame on us for making it so easy to do so." If they did manage to break it, we immediately would have them lead the effort to fix the problem as well as the effort to prevent the next person from repeating their mistake.

For new hires who came from companies with a very different culture, this was often a stressful initiation, but everyone came through it with a visceral understanding of our values. Bit by bit, system by system, those small investments added up to a robust product development process that allowed all our employees to work more creatively, with greatly reduced fear.

Getting Started

Here are a few tips on how to get started with the Five Whys that are based on my experience introducing this technique at many other companies.

For the Five Whys to work properly, there are rules that must be followed. For example, the Five Whys requires an environment of mutual trust and empowerment. In situations in which this is lacking, the complexity of Five Whys can be overwhelming. In such situations, I've often used a simplified version that still allows teams to focus on analyzing root causes while developing the muscles